

Blue BROOD

Indian politics has fostered dynasties, and Orissa is no exception to the rule

In a state where poverty is widespread, political dynasties have established firm roots in the minds of the voters. From 1980 till 1998 it was JB's family that dominated. After the death of Biju Patnaik in 1997, Naveen stepped in and thrived in the name of his charismatic father who was an icon of Oriya pride. While the Congress high command has grounded two other Patnaiks, former chief minister J.B. Patnaik and his wife Jayanti, Soumya Ranjan Patnaik, his son-in-law and a media baron, is in the fray. Rivalling the Patnaik dynasty, is another former chief minister, Giridhar Gamang, a tribal leader. Last week he forced the party leadership to renominate his wife Hema Gamang besides his son Sisir. Then there is another, former chief minister Nandini Satpathy's son Tathagat Satpathy, who owns a powerful Oriya daily and is again contesting a Lok Sabha seat on a BJD ticket. Former deputy chief minister Basant Kumar Biswal's two sons Chiranjib



THE BJP'S SANGEETA SINGH DEO IS ONE OF THE MANY ROYALS IN THE FRAY

and Ranjib are also in the fray.

But it is the ex-royals who have added colour to this election. Rajendra Narayan Singh Deo's son A.U. Singh Deo was a BJD minister while his grandson Kanak Vardhan (son of Raj Raj Singh Deo) was a BJP minister. KV's wife Sangeeta was a BJP MP. AU's son Kalikesh Narayan is now challenging his sister-in-law Sangeeta. At present, royals occupy three assembly seats at Bolangir, Patnagarh and Saintala. All the ex-royals who had contested on BJD-BJP tickets in 2004 had won while those on Congress tickets were defeated. The BJD had created a record in 2004 by fielding nine members of ex-royal families. This time, there are 14 royals engaged in, well, a battle royale.

sage is aimed at running down the BJP and the Congress. "The Congress regime in Orissa was marked by goonda raj, contractor raj, and its leaders are now more interested in family politics than serving the state," he says, asking the audience to "give a befitting reply to the saffron party for its attempt to communalise the state's politics". At another rally, the message is geared at emphasising the strength of the Orissa-specific Third Front (with the Left parties and Sharad Pawar's Nationalist Congress Party) and reiterating that his BJD would not join hands with the BJP or the Congress-led UPA.

By sundown, Naveen has addressed nearly half a dozen election rallies, repeating the same sentences, even the same words. The response is tepid and the message is clearly not having the desired effect. In fact, it is the message from his ally-turned-foe that is rising like a crescendo. After the break-up of the 11-year-old BJD-BJP alliance, the BJP has activated its cadres and paratrooped senior national leaders—prime minister-in-waiting L.K. Advani, party chief Rajnath Singh, Gujarat Chief Minister Narendra Modi, Arun Jaitley and Sushma Swaraj—to highlight for voters the "betrayal" by Patnaik. "All political contours have changed after Naveen betrayed us. As ground realities show the BJP is gaining since the message has hit the psyche of the masses," says BJP leader Bishwabhusan Harichandan.

Alliance Arithmetic

Congress voteshare has remained intact yet the BJD-BJP alliance ruled

YEAR	CONGRESS		BJD		BJP	
	ASSEMBLY	LS	ASSEMBLY	LS	ASSEMBLY	LS
2004	34.8% (38)	40.43% (2)	29.40% (68)	30.2% (11)	17.1% (32)	19.3% (7)
2000 (LS '99)	33.78% (26)	36.94% (2)	27.36% (61)	33.0% (10)	18.2% (38)	24.63% (9)

Figures in percentage show voteshare of parties along with no. of seats for 147-strong assembly and 21 LS seats.

Note: BJD was formed in December 1997 and BJD-BJP alliance came into being from 1998 LS polls onwards.

In 1991 and 1996 LS polls the BJP drew a blank. Clearly it started winning only after it entered into an alliance with the BJD.